anti-isolation

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/33299911.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F, Gen

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Minor or Background Relationship(s)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Post-Canon, Fluff, friendship fic, Catra-centric, focusing on Catra & Bow bonding, Friends help friends heal alright, Canon Compliant, One Shot, Healing

Language:
English

Series:
Part 25 of Outside of the War - She-ra canon stories

Stats:
Published: 2021-08-16 Words: 7,522 Chapters: 1/1

anti-isolation

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/33299911.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F, Gen

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Minor or Background Relationship(s)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Post-Canon, Fluff, friendship fic, Catra-centric, focusing on Catra & Bow bonding, Friends help friends heal alright, Canon Compliant, One Shot, Healing

Language:
English

Series:
Part 25 of Outside of the War - She-ra canon stories

Stats:
Published: 2021-08-16 Words: 7,522 Chapters: 1/1

anti-isolation

by n7punk

Summary

Catra and Adora are mostly inseparable after the war, but when Adora goes away for two weeks, Catra has to turn to the other people in her life for friendship and support. She is working on trusting that they will offer it back. One friend in particular is so damn earnest that he feels safe despite everything she has been through.

Notes

Ihave curly hair , but not the same type as Bow's, so Idid research for this and also consulted a friend with natural hair. They were excited about the idea, so Ihope y'all like it too! Melog's den is shown in make a home, but it isnt necessary to read it first. Catra's lute is similarly from implications.

See the end of the work for more notes

The Best Friend Squad having a sleepover together is kind of ridiculous when they live only a few doors apart, usually eat in the same dining hall, and even work together, but Adora is about to leave and she'll be gone for two weeks, so Glimmer took the excuse to have a small party. Catra can't decide if Glimmer just wants a break or is worried about Catra getting *lonely* or something while Adora is gone, but it's nice to have something to plan that doesn't effect which towns will get the vital resources that they need to rebuild first.

Maybe Catra *does* need the distraction, alright. Her coping strategy is climbing into Adora's arms and kissing her until the riot of emotions in her chest brightens, but knowing she will be losing her for a bit makes the days leading up to the departure hard. Catra gets extra clingy – which is an impressive feat considering that she had to be *told* to use her own chair at the war table instead of continuing to sit in Adora's lap for all the meetings. They are both less distracted this way, but it's certainly less fun.

Catra knows, realistically, that Glimmer can teleport out to Salineas to fetch Adora if Catra really needs her, and it's only going to be two weeks that she is gone. Salineas isn't even that far and Catra could even go visit herself if it weren't for the whole *water* and *busy as the queen's Royal Advisor* and *once tried to conquer the kingdom* thing. Catra has gone on other reconstruction excursions with Adora before, but only when she could go out for a day and then come back to return to her own work the next.

They will be separated for two weeks. Glimmer fetching Adora is only to be used as the nuclear option. It shouldn't stress Catra – they lived apart for three years and Catra handled herself without any other support – but sometimes she misses Adora when she has only been out of the room for an hour, and she worries about becoming… worse while Adora is gone. She is still getting a handle on her own volatile emotions and removing her rock has never helped her. At least she has Melog.

The sleepover is a welcome distraction, even if it cuts out certain activities for the night before Adora leaves. It's probably just as well – Melog is going to miss Adora too, even without input from Catra telling them to, and kicking them out of the bed for the last night before she leaves would be unfair. Adora is sat on the lounge with Melog in her lap, pinning her and purring as they nuzzle her despite being unable to scent mark for themselves, when Glimmer knocks on their door.

Glimmer has a distinctive knock – by which Catra means that it is obvious she has never knocked before in her life and only started to do it recently after she teleported in on Adora and Catra in bed one too many times. Catra, tucked into Adora's side and clinging just as tightly to her as Melog is, reluctantly gets up to answer it. Adora is kind of pinned right now, and Catra doesn't want to call for Glimmer to let herself in and get her back in the habit of doing it at inopportune times again.

Catra pulls the door open and draws to a halt, staring at her two friends on the other side of the door. Glimmer has a mess of blankets tucked under one arm, with Bow hauling an even larger bundle along with some mixed-in pillows and the big-eared stuffed animal that usually sits by Bow's windowsill. Catra was expecting that, though. All of them had to get used to rough conditions during the war, but Glimmer is a princess through and through, so Catra was expecting them to haul some luxury over. She *wasn't* expecting what is on Bow's head right now.

"What is that?" she asks, wrinkling her nose a little as she steps aside and holds the door open to let them in. She doesn't mean for it to come out as harsh as it does, but it is the way she is used to asking the question – and speaking in general – so despite her weeks in Bright Moon, sometimes things still come out wrong. Glimmer raises a brow at her as Catra's ears pin back, averting her eyes and twitching her tail as a silent signal of apology. She didn't do much wrong, but her voice was too much like the person she had to become to survive the Fright Zone and not who she wants to be now.

She doesn't know if the duo quite understands yet that Catra offering small signs of submission is the equivalent of someone else screaming apologies from the rooftops, but they have been working together enough for Glimmer at least to know this is Catra's signal that she is backing down and regretting her words. Glimmer's expression softens and she marches in, unceremoniously dumping her armload on the floor. Bow places his things more gently before he turns back to Catra and points to his head, as if there is any doubt what Catra was referring to.

"I got the idea from your helmet. We match!" he declares, sounding thrilled with the fact that he has affixed fabric cat ears to the band of his bonnet. Catra has seen him wear it several times – enough to know he has them in a variety of patterned silks, even – but it never had *cat ears* before. Catra feels her face twitch as Adora *awws* from the other side of the room. Melog, the traitor, is still purring, and their mane is decidedly calm and not spiking from annoyance like it should be.

Catra is fucking blushing. Why does she find this endearing? It's ridiculous. It's mocking. Or at least, it would be if they were back in the Horde. Catra has only been friends with Bow for a few weeks really, but even her cynical heart knows he doesn't have a mocking bone in his body. He genuinely thinks her ears are cute. Something that should be a demeaning insult is actually something that he likes. He wants to be cute himself, so now, *they match*, apparently.

"Oooo, look how flustered she's getting," Glimmer teases, grinning and elbowing Bow as Catra slowly flushes red, her ears and tail twitching. Catra huffs, folding her arms and looking away with a sniff. Unfortunately, the movement makes her eyes land on Adora. Adora's expression is soft and disgustingly fond. Melog is still happy in her lap, unbothered by Catra's rising embarrassment. She is reading way too much into this, but she is used to other people only caring about her unique traits that can be weaponized.

People don't usually *admire* her, and yet here Bow is, wearing his hair bonnet he made to match her. Glimmer snickers out of the

corner of her eye as Catra makes eye contact with Adora. Her girlfriend's expression is amused, but her gaze is all soft encouragement. She can tell from how flustered Catra is and what this means to her. Catra scoffs as if it does anything to cut the intensity of her blush and looks back to Bow. He is beaming like the sun, clearly proud of what he has done from her reaction alone.

"It's okay, I guess. Just don't let Scorpia see you in it. She'll want one too," Catra mutters. Scorpia is the only one who ever came close to Adora's level of affection for her and it took their friendship collapsing for Scorpia to realize that what she liked was an image of Catra in her head, not who she actually was. They're working on being real friends now, both of them improving and accepting the other for who she is – Catra is taken and a bit of a bitch, and Scorpia isn't just a stand-in for Adora – but she knows Scorpia will get jealous of Bow's headwear the instant she sees it. Bow smiles, shaking his head a bit fondly.

"You would need a bonnet before Scorpia does," he points out. Catra knows the bonnet is for Bow's type of hair – one that is different from her own, and even *more* different from Scorpia's - but she levels him with a flat look.

"You think that's the part the matters to her?" she points out. Bow and Glimmer both chuckle as Bow bends to pick up a pillow again so they can actually be properly arranged.

"Good point," he acknowledges. From over on the couch, Adora illustrates Catra's point, perking up and raising her hand as if waiting to be called on, except she doesn't wait at all.

"Can I have a headband with ears for working out?" she asks. She sounds stupidly excited about the idea. Catra flushes all over again, her tail and ears twitching a little as Bow grins and gives Adora a thumbs up.

"Sure, it'll be a good project for me to get more sewing practice on!" he tells her. Catra makes eye contact with Glimmer. It's a dare to

pipe up about getting her own cat ear accessory. Glimmer looks back, a slow and mischievous grin spreading on her face. Catra has no doubt that she is going to be surrounded in a traitorous group of friends calling themselves something like "the Pawsome Friends Squad" or some equally ridiculous Bow invention by the end of the month.

--

Adora has been gone for a day before. Even multiple. It's not bad, at least at first. Mostly that's because of her other friends, though. Catra spends all day with Glimmer acting as her Royal Advisor and they take Catra having more free time as an opportunity to reorganize Glimmer's old records that they haven't needed yet so far and thus haven't been swept up into Catra's carefully planned, alphabetized-by-subject-grouping system that she implemented the moment Glimmer asked her to help full time.

Catra walks with Melog in the evenings, and when Glimmer and Bow aren't looking for time to themselves as a couple, Catra hangs out with them. She misses Adora, but her friends make sure she isn't lonely. There are just some things her friends can't do for her. Some things that are stupid to need help with, but Adora was always there. Specifically, Catra's hair requires maintenance. Catra can do it herself – she did for three years, after all – but it is easier to never have something than experience heaven before going two weeks without it.

They all had the same standard issue comb in the Horde – by which Catra quite literally means *the same comb*. Okay, they had a few, but they were all kept in the locker room and dunked in a cleaning solution as they were passed around. Hair was one of the places where cadets were allowed to express individuality – they had lots of hair ties in varying sizes for getting hair out of the way, as well as

hair gel for similar reasons, but both could be exploited with creativity —but no one had special tools despite some of the cadets really needing them.

Since coming to Bright Moon, Catra has discovered brushes designed for magicats. She has discovered the joy of sitting and purring as Adora steadily and gently brushes through her hair. Catra *loves* it. Back in the Horde, sometimes Rogelio would carefully use his claws —long and maneuverable, but blunt —to thread into her hair and scratch or massage lightly at her scalp, and now she has a comb that can do the same. Her selection of brushes numbers a half dozen, some for her coat and some for her head, but she always purrs through their brushing sessions regardless of which one is being used. Adora finds it as calming to do as it is for Catra to receive.

Catra misses it as she brushes her hair in the mornings and evenings. It is starting to grow again, but despite its short length right now, it needs the attention. It makes it softer , curlier, and less likely to tangle. With Catra normally loving every second of it, she has plenty of reasons to put the time in, but it just isn't the same when she does it herself, even if it isn't painful like brushing was back in the Horde. What really breaks her is when she washes her hair for the first time since Adora left. She combs through her wet hair, and it doesn't hurt or anything, but it does feel like *nothing*.

Catra sighs, looking down at Melog in her lap as she reaches for the next brush in her routine, this one meant to dry and soften her hair . Melog is shrunken to their smaller form —not that they don't climb into Catra's lap while full-sized too, it just wouldn't work on Catra's vanity chair —and blinks up at her with slow , unimpressed eyes. They want Catra to get her hair properly brushed for both of their benefits. When Catra is happy and purring, Melog feels it too, both of them melting through the bond.

It would be absolutely ridiculous to call Adora back just to brush her hair. It would be *stupid*. Adora wouldn't judge her —Adora loves brushing Catra and would probably jump at the opportunity , actually

—but she will only be gone for two weeks and Catra can manage without her. She has gotten to the point where she can acknowledge their issues with codependence in her therapy sessions. Perfuma tells her that means that now she should start working on moving past it. It doesn't always have to be Adora—she isn't the only person in Catra's life, and she shouldn't be her sole focus, even if she remains her top priority.

Catra has other people in her life. Adora enjoys doing this, but at the end of the day, the brushing is for Catra, not her. Catra sighs, Melog hopping out of her lap and radiating pride as they shake their mane—and body—out to their full size. They trail behind Catra as she heads for her door. This is almost more weak and vulnerable than quietly asking Glimmer to go get Adora and not explaining why, but part of healing is believing that her friends—and people in general—aren't out to hurt her. She isn't there yet, but she knows one person that she believes is truly the sunshine and rainbows they project into the world.

Besides, he is the only one who will be gentle enough. Catra wouldn't trust another person she knows except Adora or Rogelio to get near her hair. She never did, but after the forced haircut, it is even worse. The idea of having someone else's hands around her head stops her dead in the middle of the hallway. Melog helpfully nudges at the small of her back, encouraging her to keep walking. Bow won't hurt her, they promise. Catra knows that, but it isn't Bow she is worried about so much as memories. She should just go back. This was stupid anyway. She isn't a fucking helpless kitten. She can brush her own *hair*-

Melog practically yowls in the middle of the hallway. Catra freezes, shrinking down and pinning her ears back as she immediately realizes Melog's intent. She hisses at them, but they aren't deterred, mewing again, loud and *demanding*. Catra's hiss cuts off as Bow's door opens down the hall. He steps out, his brow furrowed, and looks toward the source of the commotion. Stupid fucking psychic cat. Stupid fucking insistence that she do the things they think are

better for her. What if they're wrong, huh? What if she has a full-scale meltdown in front of him?

"Catra, is everything alright?" Bow asks, his voice a bit cautious. Catra sighs, glaring down at Melog to let them know that she *hates* them before she turns back to Bow, clutching the hairbrush handle tightly in her hand. Bow spots it, only looking more confused as he glances between Catra, with her tail lashing and annoyance clear, and Melog standing proudly behind her in the hallway. Catra takes a steadying breath and continues walking, drawing to a halt in front of Bow.

"If you have absolutely nothing better to do, I would like help brushing my hair. I can do it on my *own*, Adora just usually helps," Catra tells him, looking determinedly at his ear and not acknowledging the dramatics in the hallway. Her voice is tense and a bit dismissive – she is kind of trying to sound like she would think less of Bow's use of his own time if he *does* agree – but Bow's expression softens, melting like the giant fucking softie he is inside. He glances down to Melog, his lips quirking, and nods. Bow asked her a lot of questions about Melog back at the beginning. He is smart enough to figure out that the yowl was to draw attention to Catra before she could back out.

"Of course, Catra. My brothers and I used to help each other with our hair, at least when it was long enough to be styled," Bow tells her. He sounds shockingly genuine. Not that Catra thinks he is even capable of lying that well – she saw him trying to pretend to be an average guy in Erlandia – but some part of her was still expecting rejection. A bit of her anxiety eases. Now to see if she can get through this.

--

Catra is already asking a favor, but she is still picky about how Bow fulfills it. She can sit just about anywhere in their room while Adora brushes her hair, but Catra is painfully aware of hands she doesnt trust – well, okay , trusts but not in the same capacity – flitting around her head. She ends up asking Bow to join her back in her room. Bow says he needs something first, ducking back into his bedroom before emerging - rather predictably - wearing his bonnet decorated with ears.

It isnt even late enough for him to be wearing it, but he beams warmly at Catra as her tail twitches in response. He is trying to soothe her and make her feel at ease. He's so *genuine*, just like Adora. More so, even, because Bow doesnt deny and push aside his own internal struggles and feelings. Adora is working on that, but it has been a problem for a long time and it could take just as long to solve. Bow's demeanor helps soothe Catra as they return back to the safety of her territory. The brush running through her hair does the rest of the work.

"I dont suppose youll play for me while I brush?" Bow asks, his voice hopeful with a tinge of light teasing. Catra flicks her ear in response, accidentally *wapping* it light against the side of the brush as Bow works. She doesnt like that feeling, and Adora is experienced enough to move the brush out of the way in time with her movements to avoid causing Catra discomfort, but aside from inexperience with her unique challenges, Bow' s brushing is careful and soothing.

It isnt a real question: he knows Catra wont play for him. She never has. Her lute is leaned up against the foot of the bed, but the only person she ever plays in front of is Adora. It' s an outlet, something frivolous, but it is also a hobby that she and Bow share despite Catra's refusal to play in front of others. He's using it as an excuse to bring it up.

"Still no. How' s your progress?" she asks him. Bow immediately launches into a tangent about tuning and the challenges of reproducing a song by ear that was originally played on a much

different instrument. It would be a pointless conversation if it didn't distract Catra from the hands around her head. Well, rather, she is incredibly aware of them, but she is also aware of who they belong to thanks to his warm voice surrounding her. The subject he picked was perfect, a happy escape that Catra has only picked up since the war.

Though she has hang ups around music that date back years, talking about the lute makes her recall all the nights she has sat out on the balcony and played for Adora, not how forbidden anything that caused joy was back in the Fright Zone. She begins to purr rhythmically, almost following along with some half-melody from her memories, as Bow talks about the songs he is working on right now, leaving her openings to mention her own current projects. Catra just makes small noises of encouragement, her eyes drifting closed as her purr spreads to Melog, settled in her lap.

Bow brushes steadily as he talks cheerfully, undeterred by Catra's silence. Adora has decades more experience than him and it isn't a perfect substitution, but it's good – nice. Catra even finds the music discussion interesting as she lets it wash over her, making a note in the back of her mind to see if she can poke the castle librarian about getting a book on translating music keys across instruments. It would make a good present.

--

Melog likes to have alone time occasionally. Once they both got settled into the castle, Melog started to wander around it on their own when they wanted space. They were used to far more solitude than they were suddenly experiencing, and though they were deeply lonely on Krytis and they are much happier here – they are happier with Catra – they still need some time to themselves. Normally they

get it whenever Catra and Adora fall into their bed together – or onto the couch, or the desk chair, or-

The *point* is that the main catalyst for Melog spending time alone has been gone for a week, so now they are drifting off while Catra is in meetings. Catra watches them nuzzle and rub against Glimmer 's side – telling her to take care of Catra while they're gone, even if Glimmer doesn't know it – with a flustered blush on her cheeks and fondness in her heart. Melog doesn't want to leave her totally alone in the evenings, which is when they usually go off on their own, so they have changed their schedule to match up with Catra's workday rather than her usual off time with Adora.

Catra likes having Melog with her during the day – it is unlikely anything that could happen in the evenings would suddenly upset her, but half their meetings directly involve the war and the other half involve the realities of leading a nation into peace time, so there are plenty of possible unpleasant triggers throughout her day – but normally she isn't alone at night. The change is touching to her , as is the way Melog mews at Juliet as they pass her on their way out. Catra isn't translating the instruction – she doesn't *need babysitting*, thanks, Melog – but it still makes her smile regardless.

She has a number of meetings throughout the day, but nothing triggers bad memories for her. Melog shows up again midmorning and stays until she heads for her last meeting of the day, but they are too restless to sit through it, so they leave again. Catra almost expects them to be waiting at the door when she gets out, ready to go for an afternoon run, but instead she walks out to find the hall empty. Melog is still excited – *really* excited, wanting to show her something – but they aren't coming to her .

Catra frowns to herself, waving a vague goodbye to Glimmer before she heads for the spiraling staircase that leads up to Melog's den in the observatory they commandeered. She can sense Melog there, excited by whatever happened this morning to trigger their hyperness. Catra would wonder if maybe a member of the Princess Alliance stopped by and gave Melog another unnecessary gift of a

pillow or something equally soft to add to their den, but damn-near everybody has given Melog something to add to their nest *multiple times* now, so she doesn't think they would be this excited by it.

At least, she doesn't think that until she sees what it is. It is soft, but it isn't a simple blanket. She draws to a halt at the top of the steps, blinking at where Melog is balled up in a nest of blankets and pillows. A self-satisfied purr rolls through the space as Melog curls around a set of two small dolls. Catra stares, her heart giving weird palpitations as she blinks down at the mini-her and mini-Adora dolls.

It is her as she was during the war , with a mane and a little outfit. It doesn't look identical to anything she has worn, but she thinks it is around the right shade to match the uniform she had when she first met Bow – because Bow *definitely* did this. Catra doesn't know anyone else who would that can sew. Actually, she doesn't know anyone else that would *period*. Melog blinks at her, a thread passing between them, sharing how they were doing their rounds and found Bow putting the finishing touches on his little project.

He was excited to show someone his work. Melog liked it a lot, sniffing at the dolls and mewing their satisfaction. Bow practically beamed, asking Melog if they wanted to keep them. Melog gently took each in their mouth and carried them up here one-by-one, arranging them in the nest for Catra to find. Catra, unsurprisingly but *annoyingly*, tears up like the emotional idiot she has always been, crossing the room and dropping down beside Melog so she can throw her arms around them.

She buries her face into the blanket. The psychic bond means hiding her tears from Melog is pointless, but they let her have it, nuzzling at her hair and grooming with slow licks to soothe her. She is the furthest thing from upset, but it makes her cry harder anyway. Okay, maybe Adora being gone is getting to her a little bit, but she is having the revelation for the first time that she really *loves* her friends – not in the same way she loves Adora, but love regardless – and the enormity of that makes her shoulders shake.

She isn't used to loving so many people. She isn't used to not looking at love as a weakness to fear. One person – *Adora* – was enough of a weakness. This isn't a mere gap in her armor, but standing naked in a field and daring any to shoot her. It feels dangerous, but no arrows are drawn. Love isn't a battlefield, no matter how much her brain wants to insist that it is. History isn't all there is or all there could be. If the last few months have shown her anything, it is that love is light, warmth, and softness.

Love is everywhere. She doesn't need to fear feeling it. She is still going to cry for a bit though. She needs it right now.

--

"How do you normally do this?" Catra asks, absently, as she carefully shaves off a slice from the edge of the metal part and bends down to hand it back to Bow. The component is tiny, part of some new trick confetti arrow Bow is developing to use in a ceremony, and he asked for her help with making it fit precisely when she wandered into his workshop. She doesn't mind, but he said the adjustments he needed to make to it were too precise to use his file because it might bend it out of shape.

"I have tools sharp enough to cut off the edge without bending it, but I have to be careful. This is easier," Bow tells her, shrugging a little as he stretches up to take the part back and carefully tries to fit it inside the canister again. He grins, pumping his fist in the air with a crow of victory as it slides in cleanly. Catra snorts, but she can't deny that she finds his joy charming – at least internally. External she would get indignant at the implication. Bow turns back to her with a broad grin.

"Thanks for the help! It fits *purrfectly* now," he tells her, his grin only spreading as Catra groans and rolls her eyes. Bow can't get enough

of cat puns. Catra would think he was trying to single out her differences if she wasn't painfully aware that he is bizarrely celebrating them. "Aww, come on, helping is a *pawsitive* thing, remember?" he teases. Catra doesn't even know why she's blushing. Bow's jokes are ridiculous. They both know she is over her big bad villainous thing.

"My problem is with what passes for humor in Bright Moon, not helping," she remarks dryly, rolling her eyes and sniffing. Her tail thuds against the side of the parts cabinet she is perched on top of as she peeks out of the corner of her eye to check that Bow isn't offended, careful to hold her upturned expression as she does so. He is still smiling, turning back down to his workbench as he fits the next part into the canister, apparently unbothered by her dismissal.

"And yet you came to spend time with me on your own. Missing Adora enough to endure the puns?" he asks, but it's good-natured teasing. Catra scoffs, shrugging from her high perch. Bow can probably see it out of the corner of his eye as he continues assembling his small payload, carefully packing the confetti inside. Adora will be back tomorrow. If Catra were that desperate, her loneliness is about to end. No, she might find herself in this workshop on a day when Adora was here anyway.

She can claim it is only because the workshop, laden with machinery, kind of reminds her of the Horde – she *did* claim that when Bow discovered Catra had a hiding spot on top of his communication array where she likes to nap, adding on that she was just there for the warmth put out by the machinery anyway – but they both know better. Catra likes Bow. She likes his sincerity and how easy it is to turn off the part of her brain that claims everyone is out to get her around him.

Besides, she has a favor to ask him, so lounging around and doing something in exchange first helps. The confetti arrow is ridiculous, but helping him with it makes her feel a little less foolish as she *hmphs* and glances down at Melog, curled around the base of the cabinet. There isn't room for them up here with her, though she

doesn't doubt that they will still try to join her at some point in the future. They mew softly without lifting their head, a gentle encouragement.

"Melog likes the dolls," Catra says, absently, like the words aren't important, but if they were, they would be equivalent to a thank you and an explanation for her presence. She watches Bow grin as he caps off the end of his arrow, turning to beam up at her. She blushes. She would like Bow to *not look at her* for this, thanks.

"Making people is a lot harder than made-up creatures like Kowl, but they came out pretty well for a first try!" Bow tells her, grinning up at her. Catra can feel the expectation coming from him. She is flustered, her tail twitching and fur fluffing up a little bit as Bow clearly waits. This is so ridiculous. She should take the out from Bow bringing up the stuffed animal he has had for years and change the subject. She certainly shouldn't ask for what she wants. She doesn't know why Bow even made the little dolls in the first place, but she can guess that giving them to Melog was a way to indirectly gift them to her.

Except Melog isn't giving them up, and Catra doesn't need a little doll of herself. Melog may love having a representation of Catra to keep in their nest, but it's the Adora doll that interests Catra. Melog isn't giving that one up either – Adora is their family too, and more annoyingly, they think it would be healthy for Catra to ask for her own. Catra hates healthy. She feels ridiculous staring down at Bow. He obviously knows what she wants to ask for but isn't offering it. That probably means he wouldn't give it to her if she even managed to ask.

This is stupid. She already owed him a favor for the hair brushing anyway. Now they are just about even. She shouldn't put herself back into debt by asking for this. She can't be rejected if she never asks in the first place. She should just thank him on Melog's behalf and go. Adora will be back tomorrow and she can stop being a lovesick, sentimental idiot. Melog meows, loud and admonishing, from the base of the cabinet. Catra scowls down at them as they

raise their head to send her an unimpressed look. Bow's expression softens, glancing between the two of them.

"Asking isn't a bad thing either," he reminds her. Catra scowls, crossing her arms as if covering her chest will stop her heart from racing against her ribs. Her tail thuds against the side of the cabinet. Fine, it's like that then. She wonders if Perfuma has been talking to him about shit like this, because early on he seemed to know that she couldn't ask for herself and would offer. Now he is expecting her to do more, apparently. Being vulnerable is exhausting.

"I would like one of Adora. You're already making her and Glimmer dumb cat ear stuff. I want this as my thing instead," Catra tells him. It's almost a demand because that is what it takes for her to get it out, but despite wincing at her own words, Bow nods enthusiastically. He looks *proud*. Catra's blush is blazing now, her arms tightening a bit around her, closing her off and making it clear she isn't vulnerable.

"Glimmer and I grew up with stuffed animals, but she pointed out after the sleepover that you two don't have anything like that. I thought you might like something for when you're apart. I'm finishing up the cat ears now, and then I can make a better set for you and Adora," he tells her. Catra feels her breath catch, her act of disinterest crumbling as she turns her head to blink down at Bow. His expression is nothing but encouraging.

He was doing it anyway, he just wanted her to make herself ask and find she wasn't going to be met with rejection. Catra has already found a book on music theory for him that she plans to hide in his workshop after it arrives, never once admitting the care she put into getting him something he would like, but Bow isn't like that. He didn't sneakily give a gift to her through Melog – he probably just wasn't happy with his first try but knew that Melog wouldn't mind its flaws.

Catra is *not* going to cry about the dolls for the second fucking time in two days. Instead, she slips off the cabinet, carefully landing on the ground beside Bow, and then turns to throw her arms around his

shoulders. Bow lets out a startled sound – Catra can count on one hand the number of times she has embraced him and most of them were group hugs, so the surprise is warranted – but he raises her arms and hugs her back quickly.

Bow's body radiates as much warmth as his smile. His hug is strong – a bit like Scorpia's, actually – squeezing Catra in just the right way that somehow makes breathing easier. Catra is going to have to tell Glimmer that she found herself one of the best men out there that she could. He is the exact kind of friend that Catra didn't really believe could exist for three heartbroken years.

--

Catra is just trying to finish her work. Adora shouldn't be back for two more hours, but Catra wants to have everything put away so she can spend the entire evening – and hopefully all of tomorrow too – with her girlfriend. Unfortunately, Bow has finished his cat ear projects, and now he's sitting in the corner of Catra's office while his girlfriend – who has teleported up to Catra's favorite nap spot in the high windowsill – makes fun of Catra.

Okay, Glimmer isn't mocking her, but she is wearing a beanie with cat ears, lounging in Catra's deliciously warm window, and pretending to be Catra wasting away from lovesickness as Bow, down on the ground, laughs and drops puns when he gets an opening. Glimmer's impression of her is dreadful and her acting skills are worse than Catra's when she was a *kitten*. The commotion is distracting, but Melog refuses to get riled up, doing peacefully on their back. The psychic connection must be faulty.

"No, you couldn't possibly understand my pain. It has been days since my girlfriend has last shown me love! The only solution is destruction. She will have to come back to me to put out the fires,"

Glimmer declares in an accent Catra doesnt even have. She feels her tail twitch. She only threatened that once and it was a *joke*. She knows Adora has good reason to be away and that she is coming back. They have kept up via tracker pad calls whenever they could. Catra isnt about to go scorched earth again. Her friends know that though, or they wouldnt be joking about it like this. No, Catra's tail is unfortunately twitching with amusement.

"You set a scroll on fire because Bow was reading it instead of paying attention to you," Catra points out, not looking up from her desk. Glimmer has her own office. It is right next door and larger than Catra's. There is no reason for her to be here except to pester Catra. Glimmer lets out an affronted squawk from her perch. The scroll wasnt important – if it were, Glimmer *probably* wouldnt have teleported in front of Bow, snatched it up, and then teleported in front of the fireplace so she could toss it inside – but Catra isnt the only one given to dramatics around here.

You would think it was a requirement for joining the Rebellion, but Catra isnt one to talk shit. Well, she totally is, but she has no stones to throw. She acts like mild inconveniences will be the death of her, but she has to balance out all the years of suffering somehow. She takes some pleasure in Glimmer twisting to glare at Catra immediately causing her to lose balance and fall off the windowsill. Catra snickers to herself as Glimmer disappears in a shower of sparkles and reappears in Bow's lap – a totally unnecessary location for her to go to, only proving Catra's point – still glaring at her.

"You destroyed reality because of a crush," Glimmer shoots back. Catra is in a good mood. She just shrugs, rolling up the scroll she has been working on and moving onto the next.

"And who waited until the world was ending to tell Bow she loved him?" Catra shoots back. Glimmer huffs. Catra was kind of floored when Glimmer and Bow announced their relationship – thus informing her they werent already in one – but her point is that if there is anyone who cant call her on the way she handles her

relationship, it’s Glimmer. They are too similar. It makes them as great as friends as they were as enemies.

Glimmer doesn't get the chance to snipe back. It’s probably for the best – the exchange is friendly and teasing right now, but a comment just a little too cutting for either of them could turn that, and she really doesn't want to have a fight today. Catra stops caring about anything else when her ears twitch and she picks up the familiar thud of boots down the hall. Melog jerks on the ground, trying to bolt upright but just flailing for a moment on their back as they are suddenly jolted into wakefulness.

Catra’s ears twitch, her tail shooting straight out as all her senses hone in on her office door. She can feel her eyes blowing when the handle turns and Adora steps through the door, already beaming with excitement. Catra matches her enthusiasm, suddenly holding as little regard for her desk as Glimmer held for Bow’s scroll. She vaults over it, sprinting across the room on all fours. Adora already has her arms outstretched, her joyous laugh filling the room as Catra throws herself into her girlfriend’s arms.

Catra’s purr feels like it as loud as Adora’s laugh as she wraps Catra up in her arms and scatters kisses all over the side of her face. Excitement buzzes between them as Catra does her best to rub her cheek all over Adora’s head in turn and mark her up with her scent again. Catra clutches to her, her tail lashing with excitement. Her purr drowns out any greeting she could give as Melog finally manages to get their feet under themself and bounds over to rub against their legs, mewing happily.

"I missed you," Adora whispers before she presses a true kiss to Catra’s lips. The kiss only lasts a few moments before Adora breaks away with a giggle, no doubt tickled by Catra’s buzzing purr, but that just lets Catra trill as she rubs their cheeks together with an unnecessary amount of force. She can't help how she wants to wrap herself around Adora and never let go. Glimmer and Bow are no doubt exchanging looks behind them as they wait for them to finish, but Catra doesn't care.

So Glimmer is right about her being dramatic and stupidly in love with Adora. Who cares. Catra certainly doesnt, not when she gets to hear the beautiful sound of Adora's laugh before she kisses her again. t' s better than any music Catra could make with her lute. Besides, she knows her friends arent judging her for it. They get it – Bow *aw*s in the background as she and Adora cling to each other. Glimmer mutters something about *dramatic gay idiots*, but Catra cant claim that she is wrong.

h Adora' s arms, she is happy. She doesnt think anyone can begrudge her for that, at least not now Shadow Weaver is gone. Their friends can get their turns greeting Adora again when Catra is done with her. She is getting better at sharing, but she was here first and they can get in line. Besides, it serves them right. This is just payback for making fun of her.

--

Bow comes up with no less than five nicknames for them involving cat puns at their first sleepover night where everyone dons their cat ears and Catra pretends not to be purring as she accepts her Adora doll from Bow. t' s a bit bigger than the one Bow made for Melog, and plushier too. t is everything Catra could have wanted. Adora coos over mini Catra and makes jokes about her mini me replacing her, but she is also obviously enamored with the way that Catra cuddles it.

"Sleep with it so it smells like you?" Catra asks, her eyes big and round like she needs to plead with Adora for this, but she likes turning the full kitten eyes on Adora and watching her crumble in an instant. Her resolve when Catra looks at her like this might as well be nonexistent for how quickly it fails. Adora beams, leaning forward to kiss her head, right at the base of her ears which have become such a hot commodity apparently.

“Of course. Im not going away again for awhile though. Idont like leaving you,”Adora tells her , wrapping an arm around Catra’s side and drawing her into her side. She looks ridiculous with the plushy ears poking out from her headband. Adora let her hair down as if the ridiculous part was a headband pulling back hair already in a ponytail. Catra’s face twitches from trying not to laugh every time she looks at Adora with her stupid fake ears. She shakes her head, happily leaning into Adora’s warm embrace.

“I wasnt alone,”she assures, her voice soft as her gaze drifts over to where Bow and Glimmer are bickering good-naturedly about how to set up their pillow nest this time. Amongst the pillows is Kowl once again, as well as an unnamed pastel bat plushie with sparkly cheeks from Glimmer’s own collection of stuffed toys. Catra missed the hell out of her girlfriend, but she has felt true loneliness before, lost in a sea of isolation that was partially her own making, and she didnt experience that when Adora was gone.

She had her friends. She wasnt alone.

End Notes

Owl is Bow's animal companion from the original show, but he has a stuffed animal of him in his bedroom in the reboot. I remember spotting it at one point (I think it might be shown in The Sword Part I actually).
Shoutout to Mal for helping me come up with cat puns Also here's a cute fanart of Catra with an Adora doll that gave me the idea for that scene.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!